

Hollerbeier Haven

Newsletter for the Herbal and Healing Arts



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Spring Greetings!!

With the full presence of spring engulfing the earth it has been easy to find buoyancy in these last few months. We have been glad to see so many of your faces at the Guild Gatherings, creating a growing community around Braucherei that has been lacking for nearly a century.

The Braucherei Weg course is in full swing, and all of the students involved (whether near or far) have been adding greatly to this important discussion of Braucherei. Jesse has established a rhythm of teaching and recording, and the classes are moving easily and smoothly. We have moved the bulk of our classes Gatherings to the Historical Society in Kutztown, PA. The Historical Society has been very supportive and helpful in our move, and we have a lovely space to work in.

Down in Pottstown, at the Farm at Coventry, Susan's 'Homestead Herbalism' course is filled to capacity and her new monthly 'Herbal Hands' workshops have been met with great response. The teaching gardens are enjoying the best spring in years, with April and May rains producing welcome abundance. Two traditional four square gardens were added this spring with a long list of traditional PA German herbs planted. Susan has also been invited to be guest speaker at the International Herb Association Conference in Gettysburg in July. Her presentation will be a slide show and talk about Medicinal and Folkloric Plant Uses of the PA Germans.

Lauren is nearly done transcribing the interviews we received from Dennis Boyer, and her work in this effort has been invaluable. Some of the information she has gleaned will be presented at the next Guild Gathering at the end of May: 'The Tools and Techniques of Braucherei'. In addition to this we are gearing up for a new round of interviews, as we have been contacted by several elders who wish to share stories, prayers, and herbal cures, further contributing to this project.

Patrick has been very busy with school projects (he spent the last semester restoring an old loom to a functional and beautiful condition), but he still found time in April to share a wonderful presentation on Kabala for the Braucherei Weg course as well as the Guild. His work and research has given us a deeper understanding of the influence and importance of Jewish mystical tradition hidden within the folds of our own folkways. Patrick has also been exploring the deeper meanings and origins of the symbols used in hex signs, a project that he will inevitably share at a future Guild Gathering.

Our summer looks to be very busy this year! In addition to the Guild Gatherings, workshops, and lectures we already have planned, we are thrilled to have been invited to set up a booth at the Kutztown Pennsylvania German Festival from June 28th to July 6th. We will be present for the entire week to share information about the Braucherei tradition with the many attendees of the festival! It will be a rewarding (and exhausting!) week to be sure! The festival is a fun and entertaining event and we hope you will consider coming sometime during the week. For more information regarding the Festival schedule, visit www.kutztownfestival.com

Oh, and speaking of websites! Our Three Sisters Center website and the Farm at Coventry website and blog have all been beautifully updated since our last issue. If you have access to the internet, we hope you will come and spend some time seeing what we have been up to.

Blessings, Jesse and Susan



The Three Sisters Center for the Healing Arts is recording stories, interviews, memories, and knowledge of the healing traditions of Pow-wow or Braucherei. We are creating an archive of this tradition in order to preserve our heritage and ensure the practice. If you know anyone who practices or has a story to tell, we'd love to hear from you; whether you'd like to give a personal interview or prefer to remain anonymous, simply write to us. Your personal experiences are culturally valuable and will be treated with the utmost respect. You can contact us with questions or information by writing to:

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Meet two new members of the *Three Sisters Center Family!*

Lauren Sicher is a serious student of the PA German culture and language. She is currently pursuing her bachelor's degree through Prescott College. Lauren has studied the language and culture of her people, and has recently committed herself to the Braucherei Path. She is apprenticing with her brother, Matthew Sicher, and taking the *Braucherei Weg* course this year. Lauren has undertaken a great challenge during her apprenticeship: she is transcribing the interviews of over 80 Braucherei practitioners, and organizing the information in a coherent way so that it is of use to the work of the Three Sisters Center in the future. We, at the Three Sisters Center are very grateful for her commitment to this important task.

Patrick Donmoyer currently lives in the Kutztown area while working towards a BFA in Studio Art and a BFA in Fine Crafts at Kutztown University, with concentrations in printmaking and textiles, respectively. He is also working towards a minor in PA German Studies. His artwork attempts to reflect on occult and religious symbolism of the past and present. His research has primarily focused on restoration of early 19th century carpet looms as well as developing a photographic survey of the historic hex signs of Berks County, Pennsylvania. He currently works and studies at the PA German Cultural Heritage Center in Kutztown. He has also committed himself to the Braucherei Path this year and is apprenticing with Jesse Tobin

MAY DAY!

by Jesse Tobin

Spring is here. All around us are signs of the warming earth preparing to burst forth with the abundance of summer. As the earth turns her face to the sun, the story of her spirit continues. The approaching feast of Walpurgis begins on the evening of April 30th and continues into May 1st every year, and every year the story must be told of this cycle.

Hollerbeierfraa, or Mother Holle (Elderberry Woman) roams the world each year from All Hallow's Eve (Alleliebeziel) until Walpurgis Nacht. She carries along with her the spirits of the dead, for whom she is responsible. She brings them above to the world of the living so that they might find help in crossing over. Her time above the earth, however, must come to an end each year as well. Mother Holle is not only the guardian of the restless spirits of the dead, she is the living spirit of the earth itself: the great transformer.

With the first of May we see the warmth of summer approaching quickly and are preparing to put our many plants into the soil of our gardens. Mother Holle must return to the soil for these plants to grow strong and bear fruit. Walpurgis Nacht comes with many traditions. As late as the early 20th century (and maybe later) many Brauchers held feasts and ceremonies on this day, giving thanks for the presence of Hollerbeierfraa during the darkness of winter, and also for her life-giving return to the earth on this night.

In the place of Hollerbeierfraa as the lady of the night they would welcome Lady Summer: Walpurgis. They would write her name above their doors and leave the windows of their homes open to give her refuge from the still chilly night air. Brauchers and traditional farmers were still wary of the powers of winter, though, and would never put out their seedlings until after the 15th of May. This was, they said, because of the 3 frost Giants (still celebrated in Bavaria as Saints). In the Deitsch they were called Dreizeh Dachs, Fatzeh Vadder, and Fuffzeh Fooks. After the danger of the frost spirits is gone it is time to plant!

In modern days we can still honor the spirits and cycles our ancestors knew so well. Drink a toast to Hollerbeierfraa and to Walpurgis on Walpurgis Nacht, and leave your heart and windows open to welcome the abundance and blessings of the summer into your life. Take time for prayer and meditation on this day, focus on what it is in your life you need to grow, where you need the abundance of the coming season to take root. Most importantly, share this day with loved ones. Our communities are the soil in which our lives take root, abundance cannot grow in barren soil, and we must take care to always feed and enrich the lives of those around us as they feed ours.



*From Fairy Tales by Hans Christian Andersen (1932)
Artwork by Arthur Rackham (1867-1939)*

~Es Pennsylvanisch Muunraad~

The Pennsylvania German Moon Wheel

Since the beginning of time people have looked to the heavens for guidance. It seems that every major cultural group has had a coherent system of almanacs and astrology. The Celts, the Mayans, the Greeks, the Chinese, and many more have created systems of observation and interpretation of the mysteries of the skies.

As everything is in Pennsylvania German culture, our system of astrology and calendars is a mish mash of many cultural influences. The origin of current beliefs and concepts can be found in ancient Germanic, medieval, Greek, and Native American cultural influences. A great example of this calico of culture lives on in the Moon Wheel of PA German tradition.

The moon wheel is also an example of a strange phenomenon we have run into at the Three Sisters Center. Braucherei has become a catch all for information not kept alive in other areas, and we have found tremendous amounts of agricultural beliefs and practices preserved along side powwow cures. Until the early part of the twentieth century the moon wheel would most likely not have been considered a part of Braucherei tradition. Truly, it fits more clearly with the traditional ways of agriculture, and I believe it would have been seen as essential to the Braucher mostly in terms of its relevance to the growing of crops and herbs for medicinal and magical purposes.

Of course nothing in culture is black and white, and the truth is that most aspects of PA German culture blend into one another. There were huge areas of overlap between farming, medicine, spirituality, community, child rearing, animal husbandry, and trade work. Imagine a circle that encompasses the whole culture, and each aspect of the culture is a circle within that circle. They don't all keep clean lines far from one another; they overlap so continuously that it is hard to say if there is even one aspect of farming that is only farming, or one aspect of medicine that is only medicine. Like the organs of our bodies these aspects of culture are so interconnected and interdependent that they only truly make sense as a whole. This is the reality of culture we have inherited, and it is one that makes it impossible to sort out what exactly Braucherei is.

As I have said, the majority of use of the moon wheel would have been for agricultural purposes, but there was another side as well. The moon wheel we have today exactly lines up with and reflects the Greek moon wheel of the 12 zodiac signs. The wheel begins with the Aries/Holzhaane (woodcock) moon and continues to the Pisces/Grabb (crow) moon. The information shared in this article about the various animals of the wheel will be almost entirely magical and spiritual information relevant to the time of year of each moon, as well as some information as to characteristics of a person born with that "sun sign" or

those born during the month of the animal in question.

All of these animals are clearly of new world origin, some only being found in this part of the world. Many of the animals, however have connections to European equivalents. I am sure that all of them have a great deal of ancient mythological and spiritual significance in both a European and Native American context.

Es Raad-The Wheel

Holzhaahne Muun (Woodcock Moon) 3/21-4/19:

The Woodcock Moon begins with the end of winter. In the natural world at this time we can find the woodcock involved in its complex mating dance at sunsets in open areas near water. The time of hunger is over for those who know the ways of the woodcock. The woodcock lives in marginal lands and finds food where others can't. The woodcock teaches us to adapt to our spring environment and find the new greens and spring foods to cleanse our bodies after the long winter. Like the Aries ram, who is the Holzhaahne's Greek equivalent, the woodcock teaches us to take advantage of opportunities given at this time, and to act with speed and timeliness. This is a time of plowing and preparation of our fields for the abundance that is to come.

Holzent Muun (Woodduck Moon) 4/20-5/20:

The Woodduck Moon brings to our attention the more feminine energies of spring, reflecting the feminine energies of the Greek sign of Taurus at this time. Also similar to Taurus is the focus on growing security during this time. There is still not much food that can be harvested, but the time is coming closer when the abundance of summer will overwhelm us with its presence. It is during this moon that our seeds and seedlings are planted into the earth and committed to her care for the season. The Holzent lives along streams and nests in the hollows of trees. She unites earth, air, and water and her symbol of power is a depiction of air and water flowing into and out of a tree. During this moon is the important feast of Walpurgisnacht, as well as the nights of the three frost spirits on the 13th, 14th, and 15th of May. It is because of these spirits that most people do not put any plants out until after the 15th of May.

Forrell Muun (Trout Moon) 5/21-6/20:

The Trout Moon reminds us (like its Greek counterpart, Gemini) that swift and diverse action is needed in this time of the year. The tasks of June are many as crops begin to ripen, and we must move with quick assuredness to act in accordance with the requirements of this time. The trout lends his watery energies to bring a bit of extra rain during this month, staving off the dryness of the late summer's heat. The end of the trout moon brings us to the apex of the solar year, a mixture of fire and water.

By Jesse Tobin

BEE WATCHING *by Susan Hess*

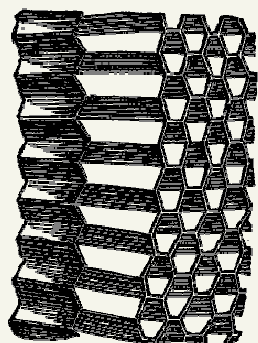
This spring I was fortunate to have new bee hives brought to the farm by a local beekeeper. Last summer, in passing, I mentioned how much the honeybees enjoyed working the catnip and elder blossoms when they visited my gardens. This opened a dialogue that culminated in the delivery of 40 hives this spring. I have visited the yard many times since their delivery-never too close, mind you,-but just enough to hold my fascination with these industrious creatures.

Though I have no desire to learn the art of beekeeping myself, I do admire those who choose to engage in the 'bee dance'. I also greatly admire the products that the bees provide for us, preferring the use of honey over other sweeteners wherever possible and enjoy infusing tasty herbs in the honey, as well.

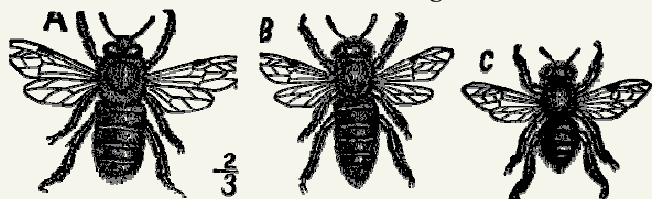
Having the bees as neighbors has given me a whole new respect for their industrious mission. It makes me happy to see so many in the gardens, feeling that we are sharing a communal industry by working side by side.

The Germanic peoples were bee keepers for centuries before their arrival here, bringing their skeps and honeybees with them from various parts of Europe. America had no native honeybee, so 'wild' swarms that we see today are just younger generations of the original escapees.

Pennsylvania quickly became known as 'the land of the bee' and by the time of the American Revolution it was recorded that nearly 30,000 pounds of beeswax



was exported from the ports of Philadelphia. The bee became a symbol for thrift and industry in the state and played an important role in the economy of the farm. On some farms the bees were considered part of the family and so it was felt necessary to keep the bees informed of births, marriages and deaths in



Honeybees and Comb, p. 1031.



the family. It was customary in Berks County in earlier centuries to drape the bee hives with dark material when their keeper passed on.

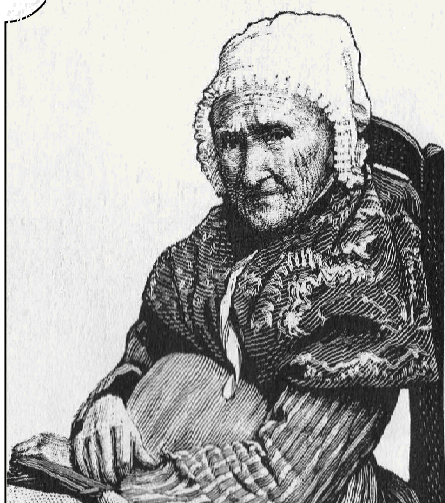
There was a belief that the bees would swarm or stop producing honey if someone did not inform the bees of his death. There was also a belief that if the beekeeper's son carefully moved the hive a few paces to the right, the bees would understand that the old man had passed on and that the new generation would be there to tend to them from then on.. This practice was known as 'ricking'.

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From 'Beliefs and Superstitions of the
Pennsylvania Germans' (1915)
by Edwin Miller Fogel, Ph.D.

*Im dunkle Mund kehrt
mer's Haus aus, no
grickt mer ken Schaawe
odder Schpinne*

Translation to be found somewhere within the
pages of this newsletter!!



Voices of the Elders

Brauchers consulted different things such as almanacs, standard zodiac systems, and their own version of the Native American Medicine Wheel. Many in the Pikeville area used a less complex Medicine Wheel version of their own, which contained some unique information to this area. This calendar influenced mostly Eastern Berks County like Oley, Bowers, Pricetown, and Hereford. The Pikeville Calendar came from a Pikeville Braucher whose Braucherei system was one of the most complete we have seen. There is a lot of speculation that there must have been significant indigenous influence, but none of our sources are sure of tribal influences, though most often influences in the Pikeville area tended to be of Lenni Len'ape or Seneca origin. The calendar that follows has brought in many aspects of mysticism, healing, and ritual. The months were broken down into times of ritual which were named in such ways to what was to be done.

THE PIKEVILLE CALENDAR:

Weisszeit (White time) – January 20 to February 18. Time of preparation and deep understanding. Winterfescht (Feb. 2) is the feast of this time.

Windzeit (Wind time) – February 19 to March 20. Time of rapid change and adjustment.

Gebortzeit (birth time) March 21 to April 19. Time of awakening and renewal. Freihlingfescht (Spring Equinox; March 21) is the feast of this time.

Blanzeseit (Planting time) April 20 to May 20. Time of past growth. Moifescht (May Day, May 1) is the feast of this time

Bluschzeit (blossom time) May 21 to June 20. Time of new ideas taking shape.

Landaagzeit (long day time) June 21 to July 21. Marks the turn over in the cycle, time of fulfillment of promises. Hochsunnfescht (summer solstice) is the feast of this time.

Reifzeit (Ripening time) July 22- August 21. Time of rest before harvest. Feierfest (August 1) is the feast of this time. (Original material noted this was originally the time of county fairs).

Sammlezeit (gathering time) August 22 to September 21. Time of bringing in the harvest.

Rotbledderzeit (time of red leaves), September 22 to October 22. Time of slow adjustments and readiness. Schpotaahrfescht (autumn equinox) is the feast of this time.

Frierezeit (freezing time) October 23 to November 22. Time of maturity and patience. Seelenachtfescht is the feast of this time.

Langnachtzeit (long night time), November 23 to December 21. Time to seek out truth and opportunity.

Dunkelzeit (time of darkness). Time of isolation and wisdom. Holzfescht (winter solstice) is the feast of this time.

Some of these feast days correlate with Nordic and Celtic seasonal events but doesn't necessarily mean that the traditions and meanings come exclusively from these traditions. Some of the people who used the Pikeville Calendar suggested that geographical directions were referenced to the seasons and "moon" in the same way found in medicine wheel systems. It does not appear that any of the four used the system in conjunction with a fixed or mobile collection of marker stones that one usually finds in medicine way systems.

Using the Pikeville Calendar we can become more in touch with our surroundings and ourselves. By trying to practice the workings of this calendar we can get ourselves into a routine to help us break unhealthy patterns and work through them. Correlating it to our outside surrounding we can become more in tune with nature and learn how to live in harmony with its patterns. I encourage everyone to at least look it over and see if patterns you have come up in correlation with these seasons. Pay attention when certain emotions or feelings come up with different times or personal cycles happen in perfect accordance with this traditional calendar. Maybe you feel more withdrawn and internal in the winter or you do the "spring cleaning" without really thinking of that idea specifically. Integrating our lives back into a seasonal and harmonious cycle is the first step towards both sustainability and revival of our traditional ways.

By Lauren Sicher

Feoh - Cattle - The First Rune

by Patrick Donmoyer

*"Feoh byþ frofur fra gehwylcum.
Sceal ðeah manna gehwylc miclun hyt dælan
gif he wile for drihtne domes hleotan."*

These are the opening lines to an ancient Anglo-Saxon poem metaphorically explaining the significance of the runes.

A modern English translation offers the following explanation:

*"Wealth is a comfort to everyone
Yet each must give freely
if he will glory in heaven"
-Horik Svenson, The Runes*

While this English translation is based upon a Medieval Latin version and syncretizes both pagan and Christian concepts, the essence of this poem remains the same. This rune literally means "Cattle," and serves as a symbol not only for a key component of successful agricultural livelihood in ancient society, but functions simultaneously to represent wealth and it's necessary upkeep. As the ancient Germanic tribes remained semi-nomadic herdsmen until the spread of Christendom, cattle represents the sum total of one's worldly possessions and their flexibility in working with the living world to support life in their community. It is the first rune in the sequence of 24, and forms a starting point for understanding the cultural context of the ancients who utilized this system of writing. Just as the ancient and modern Hindus revere the cow as a symbol for the feminine, nurturing qualities of the earth, the ancient Germanic tribes recognized the cow as a life-giving creature which enabled their people to thrive. Thus, the concept over which this rune presides is living wealth which fosters material human existence. The cow, Feoh, can therefore be identified as sharing characteristics with the earth goddess.

This wealth however is not merely a means to an end, nor is it an object to be passed on or inherited without due responsibility. Feoh represents that which must be nurtured, as livestock must be tended with care to ensure both its survival and the survival of the people who depend upon the well-being of the herd. This rune symbolizes an exchange of energy, an agreement between people and the earth. It reminds us of the fact which Judeo-Christian wisdom explains as "The Lord giveth, and the Lord taketh away" - in other words, that which we borrow from the earth and convert to our uses must be honored as it never remains ours for very long and can easily pass away.

This rune portends thus: Life may be sustained and success may be awarded, despite adversarial conditions, to those whose intentions reflect conscientious forethought. To borrow another metaphor from the Hindus, Feoh can be seen as a Germanic interpretation of the Karmic Cycle.

To explain briefly how this rune functions in divination along with its 23 counterparts, an introduction to rune casting must be delineated. The ancients carved the sequence of the runes onto 25 objects which could range in size, shape and material. In most cases, these are typically small, portable pieces of stone, wood, bone or any other available material originating from the natural landscape that held significance to the creator of the specific set of runes. An extra blank rune was often added to the sequence of twenty-four to represent the changeability of fate and potential reality. While many methods exist to interpret meaning from a set of runes, the commonality of those methods is a format of beginning by internalizing an intention, question or request about which one requires clarification and a wisdom to inform their perspective. A rune is selected at random and allowed to fall according to chance onto a level surface, where it will come to rest in an orientation that must be identified as upright or inverted. While some methods use several runes, other require only one. The orientation changes the meaning of the symbol, and depending upon the number of runes used for the casting, a rune's meaning is influenced by its proximity to other runes and their orientation.

For instance, while Feoh symbolizes wealth and life's abundance when oriented upright, an inverted Feoh could indicate that one has not, or will not act with forethought enough to obtain that which is desired, or that in the short term, a delay or impedence will divert one's energy from manifesting a positive yield from one's efforts. This need not absolutely imply negativity or loss, for other runes involved in the casting could elucidate the nature of the adversity, or mitigate the loss by providing a broader perspective.

This explanation of Feoh is the second in a series of writings intended to explain each rune in detail, with the proper mythological and cultural context to provide an accurate foundation upon which one can begin their journey with this esoteric writing system. Each quarter a rune will be explained in sequence, along with pertinent information concerning the nature of divination and different methods of rune-casting. Next issue will delineate the second rune, Auroch, along with an explanation of the most simple casting technique which can be referred to as a one-rune cast. This will contribute to a wholistic and comprehensive instruction in the ways of the ancients and their interactions with written thought embodied by the leaves of the tree of life, Yggdrasil.



Es Raad— The Wheel continued from page 4...

Schpeecht Muun (Woodpecker Moon) 6/21-7/22:

The Woodpecker Moon is born with the summer solstice or *Sonnenwenden* as it is called in Braucherei. The Summer solstice is a special time in the zodiac. The Greek sign of Cancer (the counterpart of the Deutsch Schpeecht) is the most feminine sign of the zodiac. It is a water sign (a feminine element), which is ruled by the moon (the most feminine of planets). This sign comes at a time when the sun (the most masculine of planets) is at its apex- the height of masculine energy during the year. Interestingly the solstice occurs coming out of the Trout Moon of Braucherei (a watery sign for PA Germans, but not for Greeks), and into the time of Cancer (a watery sign for Greeks but not for PA Germans). This is a time of balance between the sexes. Ceremonies conducted at the solstice should focus around the inclusion of both fire and water- often there were dual purification rites during this festival in ancient times. The woodpecker's presence during this moon is a welcome sign of resourcefulness and persistence, and farmers should be careful not to cut down the nesting tree of this bird. The woodpecker also teaches us to listen to and flow with the rhythms of nature, not to strive against them or seek to control them. The woodpecker teaches us perception of these rhythms and discernment of their meaning. Listen for woodpecker sounds and signs during this moon.

Frosch Muun (Frog Moon) 7/23-8/22: The Frog Moon comes with its Greek counterpart, Leo. Though the frog is decidedly more diminutive than the lion, its voice dominates the nighttime sounds of the summer months. Like the lion, the frog teaches us to make our voices heard at this time to take control of our own destinies. Historically this is a time to tie up financial and business loose ends and begin the preparations for winter's season with the onset of the harvest and the putting up of food. Frogs, like our crops, need water. The late summer season is often the driest of growing year, and crops are thirsting. The presence of the frog at this time serves to remind us of the fragility of life and the sacredness of water. Frog teaches us to conserve water, and maintain healthy waterways for the natural world and ourselves. When farmers irrigate at this time they should be sure not to deplete the water resources through overuse.



Schilgrott Muun (Turtle Moon) 8/23-9/22: The turtle, like its Greek equivalent, Virgo, has a long history of association with the earth, virgin motherhood, and the sustenance of us all. This is the peak of the harvest, and the self-reliant turtle (who carries its home on its back) teaches us to draw on our inner resources at this time. The turtle is well known for its slow but steady nature. In a time when the frenzied activities of preparations for winter are at their peak the turtle teaches us that a break-neck speed cannot be sustained, better to set the pace of a marathon runner, to reach the end of the harvest with a steady pace and welcome winter's rest. This late summer season is still warm enough, but not too hot. It is a good time to conduct repairs on homes, dig root cellars, and develop protections needed for the coming cold and dark. The turtle teaches us to strengthen our powers of perception and use the power of our minds to solve problems with the powers of creativity and logic. The turtle moon ends with the Fall equinox and the official onset of autumn.

Baer Muun (Bear Moon) 9/23-10/22: The Bear Moon teaches us to store appropriately for the long rest of winter. During this month the Harvest Home feast is celebrated. At Harvest Home the best of the harvest of the entire community is brought forward to the church altar to be blessed and enjoyed. It is time to give thanks (this was the traditional Deutsch thanksgiving) for a good harvest and strong community. It is these two blessings that gave our ancestors the fortitude to survive long, cold winters before the modern age. The bear reminds us to rely on our inner strength and resources in times of challenge and lack. With the onset of winter bear reminds us of the power of the unconscious mind, bear teaches us to dip into this well to find deeper truths, answers to difficult questions, and our own inner strength. During this month the first cold nights come, and the leaves fall from the trees, leaving the barren landscape of winter. The Greek counterpart of the bear moon is Libra.

Fuchs Muun (Fox Moon) 10/23-11/21: The time of the fox, like its Greek counterpart, Scorpio, is a time of twilight, shadows, and shape shifting. The fox fills the place of the trickster here, intelligent, resourceful, and often underestimated. The intentions of the fox are hard to know, as he keeps them quite close and secret, and often has the ability to hide and go unseen. The fox has been known to symbolize family unity, something that is needed in this time as the cold nights are starting to come. The Fox Muun is the time of one of the most important feasts of the year: Allelie-beziel, or Halloween. In the wheel of the year this is the time of death. The very last of the harvest comes at this time: apples, squash, and kale. The frosts have come and laid the fields bare. Slaughter time is here, when excess livestock are butchered, and their meats cooked, smoked, pickled, and put up in the root cellar with all the other foods that will sustain us through winter. This is a time to look for signs at sunset. It is a time of easy communication with the spirit world as the wild hunt emerges from the soil. It is also a time of tricks and mischief as the spirit world takes a stronger hold and tests the boundaries of our spirits.

Continued on page 9...

Es Raad-The Wheel continued from page 8....



Eil Muun (Owl Moon) 11/22-12/21: The Eil Muun takes us through the darkening nights of late autumn to the winter solstice, Sonnenwenden, the beginning of Winter, and the returning of the Sun. The owl, like the Greek sign of Sagittarius is an animal that is known for wisdom and knowledge. It is always ready to take in more to feed its thirst for knowledge. This is a time to spend long nights with loved ones in story telling and study. The owl is also an animal associated with the White Haired Woman. Historically owls have been associated with magic, witches, wisdom, and nighttime. Their keen powers of perception in the night, and their association with spirit world teaches us to keep ourselves aware for messages from the spirit world during this time as we approach the feast of Yule.

Aadler Muun (Eagle Moon) 12/22-1/19: The Aadler Muun begins with the most important feast of the year. The Yule feast has long been a twelve-day time outside of time for the Germanic peoples. At the onset of the feast we see the sun diminishing to its shortest days. With Christmas day it begins to return, and with the New Year it is growing in earnest. The Eagle moon is a time of renewal, when we catch a glimpse of the spark of spirit we must grow with the sun in this year. This is a time of deepening, contemplation, and watchfulness. It is a time to look deep within and decide what aspect of your spirit will become your focus of growth for this year. This is a time for decision and meditation, not one of action. The eagle is the bearer of blessings and transformation. He sees all things on earth and rules the sky. He brings messages to you from the spirit world above. Look for him at open water in this time of the year. As the sun begins to grow, so begins the long journey of the soul out from its deepest repose to the full vibrancy of life. The Greek equivalent of the Aadler Muun is Capricorn

Grundsau Muun (Groundhog Moon) 1/20-2/18: At first perhaps it is hard to see the connections between the Greek sign of Aquarius and the lowly Grundsau (groundhog). We must take a closer look. Aquarius is a sign of the visionary, prophet, the psychic. Those of the sign of the water bearer are often known for being "off in another world", and sometimes have a hard time living in this one (or at least abiding by its rules). The Groundhog, by contrast is not a being of outer space, but one of the deep soil, burrowing far beneath the ground's surface to make its home. The groundhog is much more, however than a grumpy subterranean rodent: he is a prophet. Now we might think the festivities surrounding groundhog's day to be nothing but superstition and silliness. In the old times, though, when the time of hunger was approaching, the groundhog was a messenger, telling the people of earth how soon the soil would be ready for planting. This little prophet was so beloved that he came to be known as a symbol for the PA German people as a whole, nearly to the same level as the lovely Distelfink. The Grundsau Muun comes near the end of winter, and carries with it the feast of Lichtmess. Lichtmess has traditionally celebrated the lambing season, women's creative power, and the time of spring-cleaning. In the times long gone, spring cleaning was no joke, and the day before Lichtmess would find female Brauchers in a frenzy of cleaning... every corner, every crack in the wall must be cleansed and purified. Even the fire would be "switched over" (allowed to burn out and then started fresh from birch and juniper). All the energies of the homestead were purified and made ready to receive the blessings of the coming spring. The Grundsau himself is a returning journeyer, coming up from the spirit world to bring us messages. He teaches us to be observant, to get in touch with our own prophetic natures, and to communicate with the spirit world during this time. He also teaches us to be of service to divinity, fellow humans, and the natural world.

Grabb Muun (Crow Moon) 2/19-3/20: The Grabb Muun teaches us to overcome adversity in lean times. Pisces is the Greek counterpart to the Crow, and both bring us to the end of the astrological cycle. The Crow moon teaches us about death and rebirth, but more importantly, it teaches a kind of resourcefulness that few others can teach. The crow is the great transformer. A scavenger bird, the crow makes food of whatever it finds, it finds sustenance in places others would turn their noses up at. The crow teaches us in this time of hunger, this last part of winter before the return of spring, to find a resourcefulness within ourselves to survive and move beyond the lean times, to find plenty where we thought there was none. The crow is also another trickster, brining quick changes in weather and moods. It brings us the energy of secrets, prophecy, and magic, and connects us with the energies of past lives. Above all this is a time to look to the crow for spiritual strength and fortitude, whether this time brings you hunger in the soul or in the body, the crow has a lesson to share.



Nine Sacred Herbs *by Susan Hess*

The ancient Anglo Saxons held nine special herbs that they believed protected them against nine causes of disease. They believed that diseases came as a result of poisons carried on 'ill winds'. Not an altogether unfounded idea considering the dark age of airborne bacteria that enshrouded the Western Hemisphere during those times. *The Lacnunga*, an 10th century herbal manuscript describes each of these herbs and their uses in a poem referred to as *The Nine Herbs Charm* or *Nine Wort Charm*. It goes on to describe how the God Woden plucked these nine herbs: Mugwort, Plantain, Watercress, Wild Chamomile, Stinging Nettle, Crabapple, Chervil, Fennel and Viper's Bugloss. The poem goes on to declare:

'These nine have power over nine poisons.

The worm came crawling and killed nothing.
For Woden took nine glory-twigs and
He smote the adder that it flew into nine bits.'
But out of the worm sprang nine poisons. So
Woden took his sword and changed it into
nine herbs. These herbs did the wise lord create
and sent them into the world for rich and
poor, a remedy for all..."

'Now there are nine herbs that have power
against nine evil spirits, against nine poisons
and nine infections...against harmfulness of
the air, the ground and the sea...from poisons
that fly from the east, the north, the south
and the west...'

Apparently a very powerful bundle of herbs!

The idea of the sacred nine herbs has never quite left us. It has shifted and spanned various cultures. Some of the herbs have changed in content and have even been forgotten for a time. But

the concept of nine herb bundle has survived until today. The PA Germans have long had their own nine herb bundle. These herbs were always gathered on Ascension Day (approx. May 1) They were gathered as follows: Three from the wood: dogwood flowers, elder blossoms, wintergreen. Three from the fields: cinquefoil, catnip and ground ivy. Three from the garden: horehound, sage and thyme. The nine have also been described as three herbs, three vines, three shrubs.

There is also a wide variety of recipes for Krautlsuppe (herb soup) traditionally served on Maundy Thursday, the Thursday before Easter. A few of those recipe specifically state adding nine herbs to the pot, others say to choose three herbs.

Krautlsuppe

1 pound of herbs***

4 tablespoons butter

1 large onion chopped

1 quart water

1 large potato peeled and cubed small

You will need a large saucepan. Pick over and wash the herbs, stripping the leaves from those stalks which are too woody. Chop the rest. Melt the butter in a deep pan and fry the onion gently until transparent. Add the herbs and sweat them for a moment before you pour in the water. Add the potato to the soup. Bring the soup to a boil, and then turn down the heat. Simmer for 20 minutes. Mash the potato in the soup to thicken it a little. Taste, and add salt and freshly milled pepper. Serve with bread croutons fried in butter or bacon fat. They should be so hot that they sizzle when they are added to the hot soup at the table.

*** use at least 3 of these with a predominance of dandelion greens: watercress, spinach, sorrel, ground ivy, chervil, beet, carrot, or radish tops, Swiss chard, escarole, chicory, green onions, collards, mustard or turnip greens.



Interesting Historical Facts and Folklore

The etching above was originally found in the *Contrafayt Krauterbuch* from 1532. It holds that Ground Ivy is a very old Germanic herb which grew around the earliest habitations of Germans and was regarded by them as embodying a spirit. It is native to both Europe and eastern North America. In Lehigh County, it was fed to cows before sending them out to pasture in early spring to increase the production of milk. In the twelfth century in the Rhine-Pfalz region, the cows were milked through a ground ivy wreath to protect it from being “bewitched”. Ground Ivy was one of the nine sacred plants that were collected on Ascension Day (see article on page 10)

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GROUND IVY

Glechoma hederacea

Creeping Charlie, Grundelrewe

Ground Ivy has a vining growth habit that forms runners up to three feet long. It thrives and rambles on the edges of woods and pastures but can also be found growing against stone walls and fencerows. It produces a sharp, minty fragrance when mowed or stepped upon. The flowers are bluish purple. The gathering time for this plant is when it is in full flowering. Is considered to be at its highest state of potency in May.

Traditional medicinal uses: Ground Ivy is used for coughs, bronchitis, and pneumonia and has been used for these conditions since the Middle Ages. Ground Ivy is an expectorant, antiviral, and anti-inflammatory herb useful for respiratory tract infections with excessive yellow or green sputum. It can also be used for head colds, hot/damp sinusitis, and fluid behind the eardrum. Another popular use for Ground Ivy was to crush the leaves and snort the juice up the nose to cure a bad headache. Ground Ivy stimulates the gall bladder and bile secretion. It can be used for insufficient bile flow, expelling small gallstones, and for poor fat digestion.

A reference in Maude Grieve's *Modern Herbal* mentioned this herb was useful for painter's colic (an old name for lead poisoning) Recent long term studies have confirmed that for those taking Ground Ivy, it does indeed increase lead excretion in the urine Abundant in Vitamin C ! Ground Ivy makes a soothing beverage for colds, coughs, and sore throats. Pour one cup of boiling water over 1-2 TB freshly chopped ground ivy leaves. Steep 10 minutes and sweeten with honey. Because of the high vitamin content, ground ivy was used to prevent scurvy.

Another traditional use for Ground Ivy (also called alehoof) was as an additive in ale to give it a good taste, to help it to clarify and to help preserve it. It was well known to kill off certain harmful yeasts as well as promoting other beneficial ones.

Contraindications: Large quantities are toxic to horses and sheep but now to cows

Topical use: Ground Ivy can be used as a poultice for sprains, bruises or bug bites

LIFE TRANSITIONS *by Jesse Tobin*

Throughout our evolution as human beings, ceremony has played a vital role in our daily, monthly, seasonal, and yearly cycles. To our ancient ancestors, and even to those not so long gone, ceremony could range from complicated and lengthy rites and rituals to brief moments held sacred each day for prayer and reflection. In the lives these people led there was the constant necessity of work. In a time when the sweat of a man's brow was his only insurance against starvation, there was little time that could be called extra. Yet our ancestors found the time, made the time to honor the changes of life, to give thanks each day for the breath in their lungs and the beating heart beneath their ribs.

Now, in a time when only a small fraction of American people make their living by the sweat of their brow, we seem to be unable to find time to say thanks for our food. We have set aside time-honored rites of passage as either too brutal or too superstitious. Few among us take a day of rest during our long weeks. Few women choose to honor the cycle of the moon reflected in their bodies. Few honor the passage of seasons with the ceremonies passed down for untold generations. We are a culture full of technology, full of consumer-driven lust for the newest gadget, full of ourselves. What has the price been for this obsession? The price has been the health of our bodies, our communities, and our earth. In truth, the price has been the spirit of our culture.

Ceremony serves humanity in many ways, and there are many types of ceremony to be held. Some are the simple, daily patterns of our lives: a morning moment of stillness by a warm fire, sipping tea; sitting with family and loved ones to share food; lulling a child to sleep with stories and lullabies. Some exist in larger cycles: weekly gatherings with friends; nighttime walks in the full moon light; prayers for the dead on All Souls Day. Yet others occur only once in each lifetime: Baptism, coming of age, marriage, death. Some of these ceremonies occur only with a concerted effort, others creep their ways into our lives while we are looking the other way.

So long as we are human we will always have lives infused with ceremony, whether we are aware of this or choose to ignore it. Simply allowing something to happen, allowing these cycles and rites of passage to pass through us is not enough. The beauty of what can be is what happens when we step forward with empowerment to claim the next moment of life with thanks and joy.

Through the many elders who've passed on their wisdom to us at the Three Sisters Center for the Healing Arts, we have compiled lists of ceremonies that seemingly address every aspect of life, every transition, every season. We have been given ceremonies to be conducted for conception, at birth, and in naming a child before God. We have been given ceremonies for coming of age, for apprentices, for initiates. We have been shown the ways to honor the passing seasons with feasts and gatherings,

to hold ourselves in harmony with the natural world that surrounds us, and allow our spirits to grow with the challenge of each passing moon. We have also been given ceremonies for times of sadness and doubt: prayers for the desperately ill, ceremonies to honor the end of a friendship or marriage, rites for the death of a body and the passing of a soul.

Most importantly we have learned to hold the traditions we have been given in one hand, and enrich those traditions with our own living intent. This is what makes tradition alive. Every generation must enrich tradition with their own imprint, that which is alive in them. This is a tenet of practice that can go beyond Braucherei into the lives of all people: be conscious of your days, months, years; of the passing moments of life with your family, friends, and community. Take this moment and make it intentional, see how this practice can turn your afternoon coffee break into a joyful celebration of life, your weekly cleaning into a ceremony of purification. If I have learned nothing else from the Braucherei path I have learned this: "spiritual work" is not something to separate from daily life, to hold up and away from the muck and drudgery of work. It is thread to be pulled through every moment, imbuing every breath, every strain of mind or muscle with the grace and richness of the Holy Spirit. If you do not take this moment to make your living conscious, when will you?



"From 'Nanny's Remedy Book'"

Fixing the Itch

First off, you must try to stay out of the poison ivy to begin with! Watch where you walk and be mindful of what you touch! If you know you got in it right away, grab some juicy jewelweed leaves and stems or some dock leaves and crush them up real good and put the plant poultice on the place you touched the poison. You can also wash the skin with a strong detergent soap like Fels Naptha brown soap or dish soap. Use cold water, though and lather up good. You'll want to cut the oil before your skin knows it's there! If you want to be real sure, wash the area with rubbing alcohol afterwards, too. If the rash or blisters appear, wash the area well with just the brown soap and water. I have some more ideas for the itch... Find an old white sock that has lost it's mate and stuff it with a handful of dry oats. Knot the sock or put a tight rubber band around the end. Take that sock into the bathtub with you and get it good and wet. Keep squeezing it until it runs with "cat milk". That cat milk will stop an itch for a long time. Let it dry on your skin. If you have the oozing kind of blisters, there are few other things you can do for that to dry it up...heat up a big handful of sage leaves or oak bark in a quart of vinegar and let it simmer for an hour. Strain off and save the vinegar. Label the jar and put it in the dark. You can soak a cloth with



the sage vinegar and apply it to the rash several times a day. Some say to urinate on the rash... well, I say sometimes that may be easier said than done! Do it if you can be discreet about it. It won't hurt nothing to try. But back to that vinegar now. If you can find dry clay powder mix some of the vinegar with it to form a paste. You can apply that to the blisters and leave it dry in place. Slippery elm powder can make a good paste for the itch, too.

For poison ivy rash on hands, legs and feet you can run a bath (or fill a basin) with water and Epsom salts. Don't skimp! Make it strong. Soak for at least 30 minutes twice a day. There was a recipe here of an ointment made by the LeniLenape Indians who used mountain laurel leaves simmered in fat. That ointment helped stop the itch. They also used tobacco as a poultice on bee stings and spider bites, but I'm not too keen on the tobacco around here. Although Pappy, he might use a pinch now and then, but I don't know where he keeps it.

Challenges for a New Generation of Deutsch *by Matthew Sicher*

In my personal efforts at keeping PA German an integrated part of daily life, I like to not only study and speak it often, but also connect with other dialect-speakers. I find that many involved in continuing folkways are often doing so with similar motivations and inspirations. On the other hand it is intriguing to note some of the differences in perception and belief held amongst fellow Deutsch Volk.

I would like to share some excerpts and insights from some recent correspondence with Deutsch-o-philés (new word: lover-of-Deutsch). There are many inspiring and intelligent people working hard to ensure the continuation of our traditions. I conducted interviews with two Deutsch teachers: Rob Lusch and Edward Quinter. I would like to share and acknowledge some of their valuable wisdom.

In my experience, “tradition” and “culture” become much more tangible elements of my life with the influence of the language in which the culture evolved. After committing myself to the continuation of PA German, I finally felt truly at home in my homeland.

Here, then, are some excerpts from the interviews: I asked both of these valued teachers why it was important for the dialect to survive into the 21st century.

Rob Lusch shared this with me: “Every language has something to offer to the world. Even if its only the historical evolution or the “genetics” of the words. Our language represents the melding of various immigrant groups from numerous Germanic lands...

So that is all in the past.. What about now?.. People enjoy their local community and their local culture, and part of our local culture is our language. There are concepts and constructs that can only be expressed in the languages that have a precise word for them. Take, for example, the concept of Heemet. The English translation of “homeland” is ample to get the point across, but it lacks the emotional intensity of the word in Deutsch.

Also, folk practices are not a thing of the past; they are living elements of today’s culture, and their original cultural context includes the Pennsylvania German language. Also, since arrival, there are likely many volumes of written notes and books in the language that have yet to be fully explored; without knowledge of the Deutsch, their precise meanings would be lost forever. And, if for no other reason, we owe it to our ancestors who built this land, to continue the honorable culture that they developed. As long as there is a Pennsylvania German Volk, the Deutsch language is relevant.”

In talking with Edward Quinter, an important point addressed was that the loss of a language is often synonymous with the loss of identity. A culture’s language is in many ways the keystone of their identity. When the language disappears, and culture becomes merely a spectacle, only “fossilized” traditions and notions remain.

The dialect is spoken now by only a fraction of the population when compared to the percentage of Pennsylvanians that were PA German speakers throughout our history. This clearly illustrates that there are elements of modern life that lead people to believe that the continuation of PA German is not important.

In asking what was the greatest inhibitor in the continuation of the dialect, I received some sobering feedback.

The fact is that it was made illegal to teach or speak PA German in Schools by the State of Pennsylvania’s Anti-German Law of 1911. I have heard stories from a number of Elders that in the one-room schoolhouses of their youth, they were forbidden to speak in PA German.

Ed Quinter points out the sad truth that the people themselves may be the greatest force endangering the survival of our Mother tongue. The simple fact is that a language cannot grow with a people if they do not teach their children and speak it in public.

This is said with full knowledge of the stereotypes and judgment endured by PA German speakers throughout our history, and into modern life. America as a whole seems to be entering a time when multi-culturalism is accepted and encouraged in many ways. We must do our part to insist that the value of PA German language and culture be seen in the ever more colorful tapestry of America.

Rob Lusch also voiced that it is up to us to take the future into our own hands: “The Pennsylvania German community does not have the resources, or at least has not found them yet, to begin seriously broadcasting programming in our own language. This is a major problem that we must solve on the community level, even if it means starting modern music production with garage bands. No one else will make this happen but us, so we must do it.”

As my third question to Ed and Rob, I asked: “What is the greatest challenge faced by teachers in promoting a thorough understanding of the dialect?”

Ed believes the greatest challenge is that students have limited opportunities to speak outside the classroom. To a lesser extent, the students have to become familiar with a different sound system, often using English lettering for German sounds.

Rob’s answer was a bit more political: “Opinion will be fractured here, but my opinion is that the whole notion of “dialect” is a problem. What turns a “dialect” into a “language”? Culturally and politically, we are separated from the Germans of Continental Europe by hundreds of years and multiple wars. We have our own cultural context.

Danish, Swedish, and Norwegian are called “languages” despite their mutual intelligibility and proximity because of historical realities. Widely diverse and mutually non-intelligible languages in China are called “dialects” for another set of historical reasons. So which is right?

Continued on page 16...

...Continued from page 5

Some Bee Lore in Pennsylvania

(as collected by the Pennsylvania Folklife Society)

*Bees will work with double the energy before a rain

*When the sumac is blooming the bees are angry and sting regardless of provocation

*Catching a swarm of bees is considered a sign of very good luck

*If you rub the inside of a new hive with mint, the bees will not leave their new home

*when bees swarm, banging on pots and pans will cause them to settle

*To avoid the chasing and banging on pots, give a nearby tree a good shake on Palm Sunday. If the bees do swarm they will settle in that tree

*If the bees choose to settle on a dead tree limb, it is a sign that they will produce little or no honey

*If any member of your family is in the bad habit of swearing, bees will not work and sting easily

* To assure your bees will not leave your property in the coming year, on Ascension Day t you must thrust a knife into a loaf of bread that has been turned upside down on the plate.

Traditional Bee Sting Remedies

The inevitable sting needs quick relief. As an herbalist, I always reach for a plantain leaf (*Plantago major* or *Plantago lanceolata*) which is always growing closeby. It is also known by the name of pig's ear or ribgrass. The leaf is crushed and applied as a fresh poultice to draw out the stinger and venom. It works exceptionally well. Some other old PA German remedies that have been recorded are as follows: A fresh poultice of chewing tobacco (recently chewed!) juice of a red

A swarm of bees in May

Is worth a load of hay.

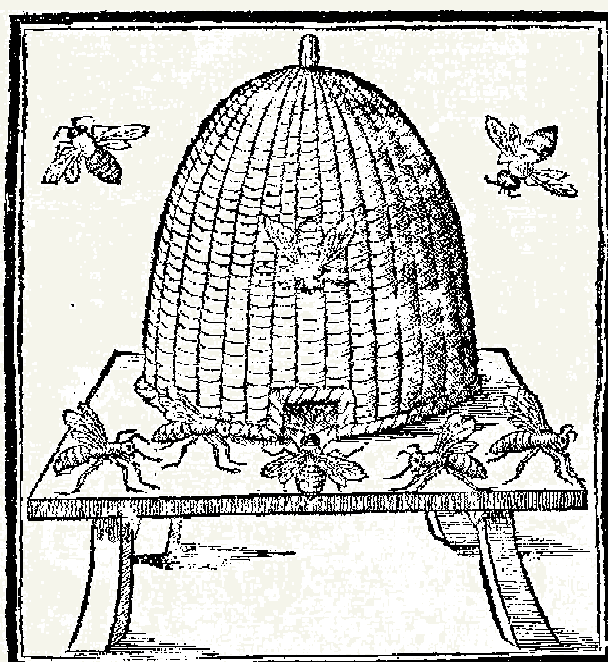
A swarm of bees in June

Is worth a silver spoon.

But a swarm in July

Isn't worth a fly.

beet leaf, a slab of unsalted butter, a paste made of homemade soap and water, the milky juice of the celandine plant and yes, even earwax!



*So work the honeybees,
Creatures, that by a rule in Nature, teach
the art of order to a peopled kingdom
~Shakespeare*

During my research I discovered that honeybees must tap over *two million flowers* to make one pound of honey by flying a distance equal to more than three times around the world. Knowing that some of those flowers are being tapped in my garden makes me feel even more enamored of my new neighbors.

A love of flowers, herbs and honey has led my interest toward yet another traditional craft. Mead is a wine made from honey and flowers or herbs and is to be considered the first fermented beverage known to humans. So keen is my interest, I have invited an expert mead maker to the farm to teach us how it is done. We will harvest flowers from the garden (either elderflower or lavender) and use it for the mead making demonstration. If you are interested in this workshop and mead tasting taking place on Saturday July 26th in Pottstown, PA, please register online at www.farmatcoventry.com or feel free to call Susan at 610-469-9591 for additional details.

...Challenges for a New Generation continued from page 14

As long as we continue to teach PA German as a stepchild of German, we'll imbue in it a sense of inferiority where none is due. Our ancestors arrived before the development of the modern German state, and our culture, experiences, and mindset are unique and separate from those of Europe. We are our own Volk with our own separate language, which leads to another, equal challenge: standardized spelling.

We need to hammer down the spelling issue once and for all. A viable committee already exists, and its focus should come to standardization of Deutsch as an independent, viable, living language."

Last I asked them both to give their opinions on the most effective way to promote the continuation of the dialect in the future.

Ed Quinter told me that a concerted effort must be made, at all levels, to revive this and other dialects. Although some efforts have been made, much more is needed. He says that the PA Germans themselves must make it a priority, but also sees that state and local government involvement and financial support would also help to support the cause at this point. He makes the point that in other parts of the world enlightened people and governments have made language survival a priority. He points out the examples of Wales in Great Britain, the Alsace region of France, the Gaeltacts of Ireland, and more. Another suggestion he shares is that Schools in the Diaspora should teach it again, and not continue the antiquated 1911 law.

Rob Lusch had some ideas as well: "Make books more widely available, get varied programming on television and radio, and make courses available at prices people can afford. People also need to be aware of the courses and where to find them. Here we can take a lesson from the Jews of New York. I used to hear advertisements on radio extolling the virtues of learning Hebrew in order to get in touch with heritage. The ads were positive and proud. We need to do the same here."

These interviews make it quite plain that there are many challenges and pitfalls to contend with as we attempt to restore the Mother tongue, but they also give us hope. The fact that there are enough students to fill Ed Quinter's University courses each year, and the grass-roots passion that fills Rob Lusch's teaching strategies give me hope for the survival of our *Schprooch*.

In sympathy with the work of these men, the Three Sisters Center is hoping to create affordable, quality courses in the dialect. We are hoping to begin these classes no later than spring of 2009. Rob Lusch will be featured as one of the instructors, and there will be others as well. For more information, contact the Three Sisters Center for the Healing Arts: 484-336-4611 or email us at Thr3sisters@aol.com

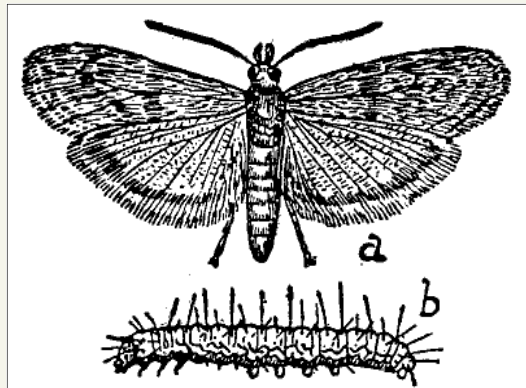


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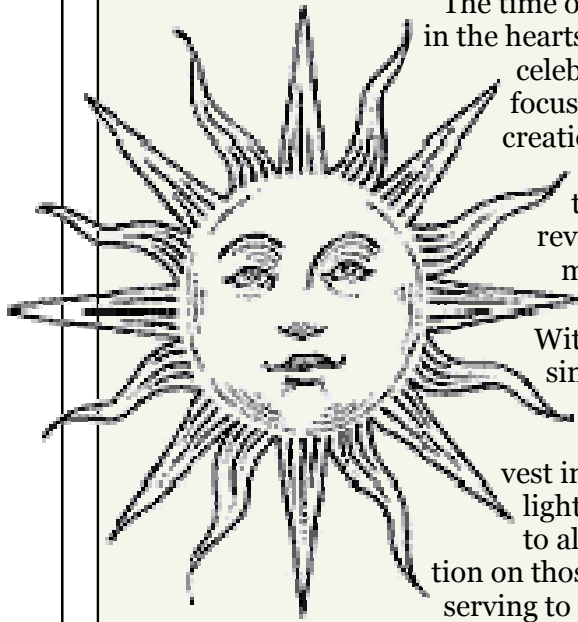
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*Sweep the house in the
dark of the moon and you
will have neither moths
nor spiders!*

The PA German dialect translation on page 5

~Mindfulness at Sonnenwenden~



The time of the changing sun, Sonnenwenden, has always held a special place in the hearts and minds of Germanic peoples. Both in Winter and in Summer we celebrate this change with feasts and family. Both are times to shift our focus. At the Summer Solstice the sun is at its apex, and the energy of creation has slowed. This is a time for purification of intention: through both fire and water. Some Brauchers would hold sweat lodges on this day. Others would bathe in open water, and spend the night revelry, leaping over fires. This day signifies the balance of the sexes, male and female, fire and water. We stand on the divide between the halves of the year.

With our minds and our hearts we have followed the growth of the sun since the darkness of winter. We have allowed our spirits to grow with the sun, and with the warming, greening earth. Now the focus must shift. Just as we must turn our focus to the beginnings of the harvest in the full heat of the summer, and as we must look to the waning light of the sun, just as we must constantly weed the beds of our gardens to allow our crops to fruit, so must we spend time in prayer and meditation on those aspects of ourselves we have outgrown, those which are no longer serving to grow our spirits. We must set our mind to weeding these deep-rooted challenges as surely as we weed our gardens and fields. The summer is still with us and the full strength of the Harvest will not come for several months. Now is the time to prepare our hearts, souls, and bodies for the harvest to come. In this moment we have the choice to clear our hearts and minds, and to become an open vessel for spirit.

Some PA German Folk Beliefs Relating to Marriage

- *If a girl goes up the steps backwards at midnight on Halloween night, then looks into a mirror by the light of a candle she may see the face of her future husband
- *Love letters must never be burned as that may destroy the tender passion
- *Marry in a snowstorm and the couple will become wealthy
- *When a newly married couple enter their own home for the first time, they must step over a broom to prevent the home from being bewitched
- *A man should wear on his wedding day a shirt which his bride gave to him
- *Yellow flowers are unlucky on one's wedding day
- *The bride and groom should not accept gifts from each other that have points or sharp edges, lest that will divide their regard for each other
- *To throw rice and old shoes after a newly married couple means good luck and plenty for their future together
- *Marry wearing something borrowed for good luck.

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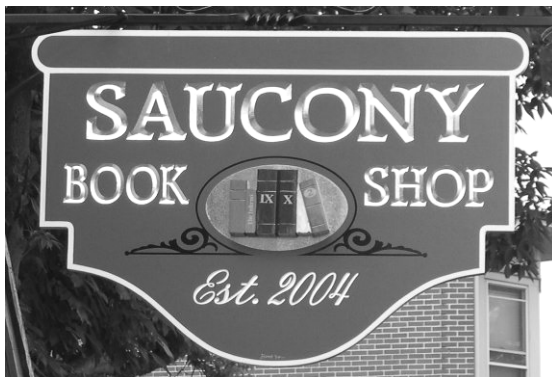
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Therapies”**

David Winston, AHG, Dean of the prestigious **Center for Herbal Studies** in Washington,

NJ www.herbalstudies.org has been scheduled for a rare , but much anticipated return to the Farm! As one of our nations’ most respected herbalists, this is a day not to be missed. The class will begin promptly at 10 am. Cost \$100 A local, certified organic lunch will be provided for an additional \$15

Register early!

For more information call 610-469-9591 or
register at www.FarmatCoventry.com

‘Hollerbeier Haven’ Guild Gatherings in Kutztown, PA

June 28th- Blanzeschwetze- “Speaking with Plants” In June Jesse and Susan will join together in the gardens at the Farm at Coventry in Pottstown to discuss the Braucherei practice of “Blanzeschwetze” (speaking with plants). They will also discuss the ritual use of herbs in Braucherei. There are several medicinal herbs that are particularly important to the PA German healing tradition. Susan and Jesse will explain in depth about some of these plants: their character, cultural significance, and use in medicine and healing ceremony.

July 12, 2008- “German Mysticism, Part 2” This gathering will focus on a continuation of April’s gathering: German Mysticism, Part 1. There is no need to have been part of the previous gathering to enjoy the information presented during this day. During the meeting we will discuss the spiritual teachings, beliefs, and practices of various mystical teachers and groups which have impacted the Braucherei tradition of healing and spirituality. Our timeline for the day will begin with the time of the reformation and continue to the present day. **Note: this gathering will not be held, as gatherings usually are, on the last Saturday of the month due to scheduling conflicts.**

August 30, 2008- “Wheel of the Year, Part 1” During our August gathering we will discuss the dark half of the year, from Alleliebeziel (Halloween) to Walpurgisnacht (May Eve). The information we will be sharing comes predominantly out of the Oley Braucherei Freindschaft. We will focus on the major and minor feasts acknowledged in the Braucherei tradition during this part of the year. In addition to this we will explore the significance of each of the six moons, of this half of the year. We will discuss the significance of each moon from the perspective of the Greek Zodiac and the Oley-Pikeville moon Calendar.

September 27, 2008- Wheel of the Year Part 2 Our September gathering will focus on the Light half of the year, from Walpurgisnacht (May Eve) to Alleliebeziel (Halloween). The information we will be sharing comes predominantly out of the Oley Braucherei Freindschaft. We will focus on the major and minor feasts acknowledged in the Braucherei tradition during this part of the year. In addition to this we will explore the significance of each of the six moons, of this half of the year. We will discuss the significance of each moon from the perspective of the Greek Zodiac and the Oley-Pikeville moon Calendar.

*All Gatherings will be held at the Kutztown Historical Society from 10-3pm \$35 members/\$45 non-members. To register fill out the enclosed form, call Jesse at 484-336-4611 or visit www.ThreeSistersCenter.com

‘Herbal Hands’ Workshops and Classes in Pottstown, PA

Wednesday, June 25 6-8 pm: “Let’s Make Fresh Cheese!” It’s so easy to make fresh soft cheese with cow or goat milk and culture. We will go through the simple processes of making a fresh cheese like Chevre’ or Fromage Blanc. Unlike cheese that needs to be aged and carefully tended for months, fresh cheeses are ready to eat within a day and can be easily incorporated into any kitchen routine using basic kitchen equipment. After the basics are discussed and demonstrated, we will get our hands pleasantly ‘dirty’ by rolling freshly made cheese into fresh chopped herbs. The cost is \$30

Saturday, July 5: ‘Blanzeschwetze’-Speaking with Plants: Ceremonial Harvest and Ritual uses of Herbs This workshop will focus on the reality that plants are vital beings that wish to be in relationship with human beings. They are available for us and our healing work just for the asking. We will learn the basics of ‘speaking with plants’ and receiving their subtle healing messages. Experiential demonstrations with plants in the garden will then be shared by all. We will then take some time to journal our experiences followed by a discussion of various ways that plants have been used in ritual and ceremony by many cultures through the ages. Please bring a small sketch book or journal to record your own experiences.

Saturday, July 26 5-7 pm: “The Ancient Craft of Mead Making” What is mead? Put simply, it’s an alcoholic beverage made from fermented honey. It is considered by many to be the earliest alcoholic beverage consumed by mankind. Mead is as diverse as wine. It can be sweet or dry, still or sparkling, and made from light honey or dark. Mead can be made with additions such as herbs, spices, flowers, fruits, vegetables. Greg Fink, sometimes known simply as “The Mead Guy”, will be sharing his mead making expertise with us in a two hour workshop beginning at 5 pm. He will demonstrate the crafting of an herbal mead (lavender or perhaps elderflower?) and will share tastings of a variety of meads and also pair them with complimentary foods. When the workshop concludes at 7 pm, there will be an optional potluck meal, garden walk and evening bonfire. This should be a wonderful event and summer evening on the farm.

Saturday, August 2: Haul in the Herbal Harvest!

A lively discussion and hands-on demonstration of the many techniques for preserving the herbal harvest. Topics will include: harvesting herbs, proper drying and storage methods, and basics of making: pesto, vinegars, syrups, infused oils, etc. Know what supplies to have on hand *before* you are blessed with baskets of basil and buckets of berries! Abundant handouts and recipes will be provided.

Wednesday August 6 from 6-8 pm. Repeat of “Let’s Make Cheese!” The cost is \$30.

**** All Herbal Hands Workshops will be held at the Farm at Coventry from 10-3pm and cost \$40 unless otherwise noted. To register fill out the enclosed form, call Susan at 610-469-9591 or visit**

www.FarmatCoventry.com to see the entire list of scheduled events

Three Sisters Center for the Healing Arts

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Kempton, PA

19529



Visit our newly updated website ! www.ThreeSistersCenter.com



Muundaag iss Weschdaag

(Monday is Washday)

Back to the washline! It is Monday as I type up this last small piece for the newsletter and yes, I can see my sheets through the window, flopping in the spring breeze! I thought it would be fun to share some old PA German washday folk beliefs with you here. Think of them the next time you do your wash on Monday!

*For a single young woman doing the wash, if a man's trousers or sock came to the top of the wash kettle, she would soon have a suitor. If a young man walked under a washline and a pair of woman's undies flopped in his face, he would be married soon

*The white wash was done first and hung closet to the house, then the colors and finally the muddy overalls were washed last and hung closet to the barn. All women's undergarments were hung around the back of the house, out of sight of passing horse and wagons

*Baby's clothes were never left on the line overnight or the baby would cry all night. In fact, it was believed bad luck to leave *any* clothes hanging overnight

*It was considered bad luck and to bring sickness for the entire year to wash any clothes between Christmas and New Year

*Housewives held silent, but mental competitions with each other to have the whitest wash. However, a woman with 'gray wash' was talked about furiously!

(Bits and pieces of this wonderful washday folklore was found in an article by Mrs. Russell Baver in an 1953 issue of the Pennsylvania Dutchman magazine)